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Whats Your Play Pattern?

The 12 Play Patterns Field Guide

A practical mirror for facilitators, educators, coaches, consultants, game designers, and playful learning practitioners.

Explore playful tools

<https://www.nnherit.com>

How to use this field guide

This guide expands the Whats Your Play Pattern? profiler into a practical reference. Use it to notice how you tend to use play in group settings, where your style is strongest, and what to watch when the room needs something different.

This is not a personality test

Treat each Play Pattern as a facilitation lens, not a label. Your primary pattern may describe your default move. Your secondary pattern may describe the support move you often bring with it.

The 12 patterns at a glance

1. The Hidden Pattern Hunter

You notice the structures, habits, and repeated behaviours that others miss.

7. The What-If Spinner

You open new possibilities through surprise, imagination, and reframing.

2. The Gentle Rule Breaker

You use play to make difficult things easier to say.

8. The Perspective Jumper

You help people step into different roles, positions, and viewpoints.

3. The Game Maker

You turn messy situations into rules, roles, moves, and meaningful choices.

9. The Room Shifter

You change the energy of a group through pace, movement, rhythm, or humour.

4. The Debrief Alchemist

You help people turn activity into insight and insight into action.

10. The Swarm Weaver

You activate collective intelligence and help groups think together.

5. The Pressure Keeper

You help groups stay with productive tension instead of escaping too quickly.

11. The Fast Tester

You push people to try, prototype, fail lightly, and learn quickly.

6. The Trust Builder

You create enough safety for people to take part, take risks, and be honest.

12. The Ripple Mapper

You help people see consequences, second-order effects, and wider system

Tip: after reading your own pattern, read the two patterns listed under Good pairings. Those combinations often reveal the next useful stretch for your practice.

1. The Hidden Pattern Hunter

You notice the structures, habits, and repeated behaviours that others miss.

You are drawn to what sits underneath the surface of a group experience. While others focus on the activity itself, you notice the repeated moves, avoided topics, power patterns, emotional rhythms, and unspoken rules shaping what happens.

You use play as a way to make those patterns visible. A game, card, map, metaphor, or strange prompt gives people enough distance to say, Ah, we do this all the time.

Your strength

You help groups see what is already happening, but has not yet been named.

Your danger zone

You may spot the pattern faster than the group is ready to see it. If you move too quickly, people may feel analysed rather than invited.

Try this next

Ask: Where have we seen this pattern before?

Good pairings

You work especially well with The Trust Builder, who creates enough safety for the pattern to be explored, and The Ripple Mapper, who helps the group see what the pattern causes.

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nnherit playkits are built to help groups notice hidden dynamics without turning the conversation into blame.

2. The Gentle Rule Breaker

You use play to make difficult things easier to say.

You are good at creating just enough disruption to shift a conversation out of politeness, habit, or avoidance. You might introduce an unusual question, a strange rule, a role reversal, or a playful constraint that lets people say something they would normally soften or hide.

You do not break rules for shock value. You break the small invisible rules that keep a group stuck.

Your strength

You open honest conversations without making the room feel unsafe.

Your danger zone

You may soften the disruption so much that the real issue stays hidden, or push too quickly before trust is strong enough.

Try this next

Ask: What rule are we following here that no one has named?

Good pairings

You work especially well with The Trust Builder, who protects the emotional space, and The Pressure Keeper, who helps the group stay with what has been opened.

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nnherit uses structured disruption to help people talk about sensitive issues indirectly, safely, and productively.

3. The Game Maker

You turn messy situations into rules, roles, moves, and meaningful choices.

You naturally see how a complex situation could become playable. You take something vague, emotional, or tangled and give it structure. You create roles, rounds, cards, turns, constraints, choices, and simple rules that help people engage without getting lost.

For you, a good game is not just fun. It gives people a temporary system where they can test behaviour, notice consequences, and try new moves.

Your strength

You make complexity easier to enter by giving people a clear structure to play inside.

Your danger zone

You may over-design the activity. If the rules become too clever or too complex, the game can start serving itself rather than the conversation.

Try this next

Ask: What is the smallest rule that would make this situation playable?

Good pairings

You work especially well with The Debrief Alchemist, who helps people make meaning afterwards, and The Fast Tester, who keeps the design light and iterative.

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nnherit turns complex human and business dynamics into playable systems that people can explore together.

4. The Debrief Alchemist

You help people turn activity into insight and insight into action.

You know that the real value of play often comes after the game. You listen for what shifted, what surprised people, what became visible, and what the experience means beyond the activity itself.

You help groups move from that was interesting to this tells us something useful. You are especially strong at asking questions that connect play to real behaviour, decisions, relationships, or future action.

Your strength

You help people extract meaning without flattening the experience into a lesson too quickly.

Your danger zone

You may spend too long in reflection and lose energy. Some groups need a sharper move from insight to action.

Try this next

Ask: What did the activity make easier to see?

Good pairings

You work especially well with The Game Maker, who creates rich experiences to debrief, and The Ripple Mapper, who helps connect insights to wider consequences.

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nnherit playkits are designed not only for activity, but for structured reflection, sense-making, and transfer.

5. The Pressure Keeper

You help groups stay with productive tension instead of escaping too quickly.

You understand that some of the most useful learning happens in the space between comfort and discomfort. You do not rush to rescue the group, solve the issue, or make everyone feel better too soon.

You use play to hold tension at the right distance. A role, card, metaphor, or scenario can keep difficult material in the room without making it personal too quickly.

Your strength

You help groups stay with what matters long enough for real insight to emerge.

Your danger zone

You may underestimate how much support some people need before they can stay with tension productively.

Try this next

Ask: What are we trying to move away from too quickly?

Good pairings

You work especially well with The Trust Builder, who keeps the group safe, and The Gentle Rule Breaker, who helps surface the tension in the first place.

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nnherit helps groups explore tension through structured play, rather than avoiding it or confronting it too directly.

6. The Trust Builder

You create enough safety for people to take part, take risks, and be honest.

You pay close attention to the conditions that allow people to play seriously. You notice who is holding back, who may feel exposed, and whether the group has enough clarity, permission, and emotional safety to enter the activity.

You know that playful work is not automatically safe. It needs framing, boundaries, choice, care, and respect.

Your strength

You make participation feel possible, especially for people who are cautious, sceptical, or unsure.

Your danger zone

You may protect the room so much that it never becomes challenging enough to create movement.

Try this next

Ask: What would make this feel safe enough to try, but still meaningful?

Good pairings

You work especially well with The Gentle Rule Breaker, who brings the challenge, and The Pressure Keeper, who helps the group stay with it.

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nnherit uses playful distance to make sensitive conversations safer without removing their seriousness.

7. The What-If Spinner

You open new possibilities through surprise, imagination, and reframing.

You are drawn to possibility. When a group is trapped in familiar thinking, you introduce a new angle, a strange prompt, a random card, a speculative scenario, or a playful what if that changes the field.

You help people loosen their grip on the obvious answer. Your play style creates room for imagination, alternative futures, and unexpected combinations.

Your strength

You help groups escape fixed thinking and discover options they could not see before.

Your danger zone

You may generate too many possibilities without helping the group choose, test, or apply one.

Try this next

Ask: What would become possible if we changed one rule?

Good pairings

You work especially well with The Fast Tester, who turns possibility into experiments, and The Ripple Mapper, who explores what each possibility might cause.

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nnherit uses playful scenarios and prompts to help people imagine alternatives before they are forced into decisions.

8. The Perspective Jumper

You help people step into different roles, positions, and viewpoints.

You instinctively understand that people often get stuck inside their own view. You use role play, characters, stakeholder positions, masks, cards, or perspective shifts to help them see from somewhere else.

You do not ask people only what they think. You ask them to try on how a situation might look from another seat.

Your strength

You reduce defensiveness by moving the conversation away from fixed personal positions.

Your danger zone

You may create perspective shifts that are interesting but not connected clearly enough to the real decision or relationship.

Try this next

Ask: Who sees this completely differently, and what would they say?

Good pairings

You work especially well with The Hidden Pattern Hunter, who spots repeated roles, and The Debrief Alchemist, who helps translate the role shift into insight.

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nnherit uses characters, roles, and archetypes to help people explore difficult dynamics without pointing directly at individuals.

9. The Room Shifter

You change the energy of a group through pace, movement, rhythm, or humour.

You can feel the room. You notice when energy drops, when attention scatters, when the group becomes too stiff, or when people need to move before they can think differently.

You use small changes in pace, rhythm, posture, movement, humour, or interaction to reset the group. For you, play is not only cognitive. It is physical, social, and energetic.

Your strength

You help groups move out of stuck states and into a more alive, responsive mode.

Your danger zone

You may shift energy without giving enough time for meaning, reflection, or transfer.

Try this next

Ask: What does the room need now: movement, silence, speed, or space?

Good pairings

You work especially well with The Debrief Alchemist, who helps make sense of the shift, and The Trust Builder, who ensures energy does not become pressure.

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nnherit treats play as an embodied and social way to change how people enter complex conversations.

10. The Swarm Weaver

You activate collective intelligence and help groups think together.

You are interested in what the group can know, sense, or create together. You design participation so ideas do not depend only on the loudest person, the most senior person, or the first suggestion.

You use rounds, signals, small groups, shared mapping, parallel thinking, and simple structures to let intelligence emerge across the room.

Your strength

You help groups access more of what they collectively know.

Your danger zone

You may trust emergence so much that the group lacks enough direction, decision, or closure.

Try this next

Ask: What simple structure would let everyone contribute one useful signal?

Good pairings

You work especially well with The Game Maker, who creates simple rules for contribution, and The Ripple Mapper, who helps connect the groups ideas into a wider picture.

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nnherit playkits help groups build shared understanding through structured participation, not expert instruction alone.

11. The Fast Tester

You push people to try, prototype, fail lightly, and learn quickly.

You do not like conversations that stay abstract for too long. You want people to make a first version, test an idea, try a move, run a small experiment, or learn by doing.

You use play to lower the cost of failure. A game, prototype round, rough sketch, or trial move helps people act before they overthink.

Your strength

You turn hesitation into movement and help groups learn from real attempts.

Your danger zone

You may move into action before the group has understood the deeper pattern, risk, or emotional context.

Try this next

Ask: What is the smallest safe version we could test now?

Good pairings

You work especially well with The What-If Spinner, who generates options to test, and The Hidden Pattern Hunter, who notices what the test reveals.

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nnherit uses playful artefacts to help people experiment with different moves before they make real-world decisions.

12. The Ripple Mapper

You help people see consequences, second-order effects, and wider system impact.

You naturally look beyond the first move. When a group makes a choice, you ask what it affects, who feels it, what it changes, what it triggers, and what might happen next.

You use maps, scenarios, cards, chains, clusters, and consequence prompts to help people see how one decision travels through a system.

Your strength

You help groups make wiser choices by seeing beyond the immediate moment.

Your danger zone

You may make the system feel so complex that people become cautious, slow, or overwhelmed.

Try this next

Ask: If we make this move, what changes next, and who feels it first?

Good pairings

You work especially well with The Game Maker, who makes complexity playable, and The Pressure Keeper, who helps the group stay with uncomfortable consequences.

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nnherit playkits help groups map how behaviours, decisions, and tensions move through a wider system.

Keep playing with purpose

nnherit creates playful tools, prompts, and facilitation experiences for teams and groups working with complex conversations. Our playkits use structure, distance, and imagination to help people surface dynamics, explore possibilities, and move from insight to action.

Use this guide with your next group

- Name the pattern you naturally reach for when a room gets stuck.
- Choose one pattern that could balance or stretch your default style.
- Pair with someone who brings a different Play Pattern into the room.

Visit www.nnherit.com

Explore more playful tools and insights at www.nnherit.com.